

The Otto Mühl Commune: self-expression, common property and free sexuality. A retrospective on two decades of an experiment about love and life (1970-1990)

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Introduction

A boy named Otto Mühl was born on June 16th 1925 in a rural area of Burgenland state, one of the economic weakest states of Austria. His father, an elementary school teacher and musician was able to provide something like a home during this very stormy period in Europe's history.¹

In the second part of the Thirties he was allowed to visit a college, but afterwards at the age of eighteen he was obligated to "Reichsarbeitsdienst". This "Reichsarbeitsdienst" was a common procedure - imposed by decree - for men and women during the Nazi-Regime with the objective to accessing a labor source. On average six months later, men were sent to the army; this happened to Otto Mühl either.²

After two in the war zone, Mühl was supposedly part of the Battle of Bulge offensive campaign, he got caught 1945 by the Soviet Army but he was able to escape and heading back to Austria.³

1946 he graduated from college in Vienna and registered later at the University of Vienna for studies of law. Not for long, Otto Mühl decided to change his study program so he began to enroll for German and History programs. Five years, in meantime father of one daughter, we graduated as college teacher for German and history.⁴

¹ Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

² Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

³ Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

⁴ Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

Directly afterwards he applied for another study program: this time at the art academy of Vienna. Actually this was the beginning of Otto Mühl's life as a vivid and controversial artist. For sure he studied the big names of landscape paintings like van Gogh, Cezanne, Gris, Picasso, Gauguin and Matisse, but moreover he dived deeper to a psychoanalytic and therapeutic perspectives. Later soon, in the 1960s, he opened a door to a radical form of painting by cutting his canvases and or by placing objects in his pictures.⁵

Wiener Aktionismus

The so called "Blutorgel" (blood organ) was a first visibly proof of what later was labeled as "Wiener Aktionismus" (Viennese Actionism). During this "Blutorgel" performance Otto Mühl and two other artists were bricked in Mühl's cellar atelier for three days to be released in front of an audience.⁶

Suddenly the body was a central part of artistic expressions and a tool for universal abreaction.⁷

„We decided to pacify humanity, to descend four days at the vault. (Where you can even wall us). Three days unlimited disinhibitions, relief from all lust, transpose that into sheet metal, scrap, rotting waste, flesh, blood, lumber [...]"^{8 9}

From now on performances became perfect frames for artistic and self-expressions. It was a perfect translation of an anti-capitalistic and anti-clerical position; it was clearly in opposition to a well-behaved average, the non-thinkers about historical responsibility, against small-minded people.

Over the Sixties Otto Mühl got regularly in conflict with law and permanently in contact with social elite. On the one hand he was sent to prison because some of his interventions endangered people, on the other hand he

⁵ Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

⁶ Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

⁷ Cf. E.S.E.L. KG, Kunst kommt von Kommunizieren, <http://esel.at/termin/74849> (12.10.2015);

⁸ Otto Mühl, Manifest "Die Blutorgel" (Wien 1962), aus: mumok, museum moderner kunst stiftung ludwig wien, <https://www.mumok.at/de/manifest-die-blutorgel> (15.10.2015);

⁹ Original: „Wir haben uns zur Befriedung der Menschheit entschlossen, vier Tage in das Gewölbe niederzusteigen. (Wo selbst wir uns einmauern lassen). Drei Tage schrankenlose Enthemmung, Befreiung von aller Brunst, Transponierung derselben in Blech, Schrott, verwesenden Abfällen, Fleisch, Blut, Gerümpel [...]"

connected with other artists of the scene, performed intensively and founded different platform to express himself and his concepts.¹⁰

At the end of this decade Mühl felt the need for new social conceptions, so after he got divorced the very first commune in Vienna city (Praterstraße) by Otto Mühl was founded under the title “AAO” (Aktions Analytische Organisation - Actions Analytic Organization).¹¹

Per contra to his colleagues, he concentrated more and more on relationship issues, basics of the so called “family values” and the need to define something new. By opening a commune, Mühl felt ready for collectivity as a solution to an old conventional system called marriage, parent-children uniformity and more..

In 1973 he performed in a public action at the Ohio State University in Columbus for the very last time, arguing, that life itself would be art. In consequence his creativity had now to be limited to his commune life.¹²

Otto Mühl's commune in an economical perspective

In 1972 the commune acquired an estate in moorland, miles away of neighbors in the middle of Burgenlands nowhere, with the name “Friedrichshof”. At the beginning the commune embraced about a dozen of people, who first started to revitalize the farm house during summer time and weekends. Just one year later they lived there permanently in a chaotic commune organization by defining themselves as clan people with one chieftain respectively shaman. Additionally Otto Mühl exclaimed “free sexuality and the liquidation of couple-constructions”.¹³

In the middle of the 1970s the commune radicalized and separated themselves of a so-called Hippie-Culture. Beards and hairs got replaced by bib overalls and wool-pullovers. Formal rules got officially propagandized: duty to self-expression, free sexuality, common property, common labor and production, common education of growing children and direct democratic processes. The commune concept had become more and more popular, so

¹⁰ Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

¹¹ Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

¹² Cf. Archiv Otto Mühl, <http://www.archivesmuehl.org/bio.html> (14.10.2015);

¹³ Cf. Peter Schär, Kurze Geschichte der Kommune Friedrichshof - Versuch eines Überblicks (2015), in: <http://www.friedrichshof.at/de/geschichte/> (16.10.2015);

other commune houses were founded in Heidelberg or Krefeld for instance. The life evolved from chaotic to a more professional way by providing repair stores, bars, kitchens, children day care and many other things. But still, the rules of self-expression or free sexuality were an immanent part of this everyday-life. Feminists and left-wing thinkers were thrilled and infuriated at the same time.¹⁴

The growth of the Friedrichshof-commune was economically difficult to handle, productions were inefficient, common assets were not enough to keep life going. So 1977 in a formal congress of the AA groups (Actions Analytic Organization) in Nürnberg, private property was allowed and the common production infrastructure was privatized again. Commune members were supposed to go back in their professions or to finalize their studies so they could contribute enough to a common budget (so called “housekeeping money”). Moreover different formats got capitalized, so guests for instance were able to book seminars of self-expression or had even the chance to purchase pictures made by Otto Mühl.¹⁵

Otto Mühl’s commune in a social perspective

At the beginning of the eighties (1983) the Otto Mühl commune had approximately 600 members who were separated in 25 groups, located all over Europe, and dedicated to the Mühls principles. More and more a visible radicalization and strict segregations from mainstream cultures established a public reputation which was quite similar to a sect. As a consequence the commune opened up and tried to assimilate more to all the world - for instance in their dress codes - so they got widely tolerated even by federal chancellor of Austria.¹⁶

Anyway critics never muted and additionally serious financial problems at “Friedrichshof” got worse, so common property was introduced again and the commune members focused intensively on themselves again by excluding, step by step, the rest of the world. Surprisingly in this period Otto Mühl got married to his “first” commune wife, Claudia Steiger, shortly after she gave birth to their son. This was a breaking moment in the social

¹⁴ Cf. Schär, Kurze Geschichte der Kommune Friedrichshof (2015), in: <http://www.friedrichshof.at/de/geschichte/> (16.10.2015);

¹⁵ Cf. Schär, Kurze Geschichte der Kommune Friedrichshof (2015), in: <http://www.friedrichshof.at/de/geschichte/> (16.10.2015);

¹⁶ Cf. Schär, Kurze Geschichte der Kommune Friedrichshof (2015), in: <http://www.friedrichshof.at/de/geschichte/> (19.10.2015);

construction by breaking of the first elementary rules of commune life: from now on the commune way of life changed to courtly manners and hierarchies. Any protests about decisions by Mühl, his wife or other members of the elite group, were not tolerated. To survive financially different dislocated groups got liquidated and united with more successful ones (like the one in Berlin). This new style of disobey common property and life, decreased the number of members deeply: all in all the commune shrank to approximately 350 members¹⁷ (including more than 80 children) who lived with or better under Mühl's and his wife's vision.¹⁸

1989 with the fall of Berlins wall, simple members of the "Friedrichshof" started to speak out loud about difficulties and inequalities in the commune structure. Suddenly there were so many members who criticized status quo that it was impossible to exclude them all and to deal with the problems seriously. Thereupon a housing association was founded where every member was legally owner of his share; moreover an election changed the decision-hierarchy completely and deprived Otto Mühl himself and his closest circle of friends of the all-embracing power.¹⁹

1991 Otto Mühl got arrested and was found guilty for drug and sexual abuse. Former commune members realized that Mühl and his wife had two faces and that many things happened, which was not part of the ideology but a result of strictly obeyed hierarchy.^{20 21}

Retrospective

2010 Otto Mühl's so called first wife turned her back to the commune's life. At this time one last enclave existed in Portugal; she came with her elders' daughter to Vienna. In 2015 in an interview with a daily Austrian newspaper Claudia Mühl reflected her past: „*Otto be-charmed us. We were under group*

¹⁷ Most of them were distracted by the possibility to build up a new commune in La Gomera (Canarias, Spain).

¹⁸ Cf. Schär, Kurze Geschichte der Kommune Friedrichshof (2015), in: <http://www.friedrichshof.at/de/geschichte/> (19.10.2015);

¹⁹ Cf. Schär, Kurze Geschichte der Kommune Friedrichshof (2015), in: <http://www.friedrichshof.at/de/geschichte/> (19.10.2015);

²⁰ Cf. Schär, Kurze Geschichte der Kommune Friedrichshof (2015), in: <http://www.friedrichshof.at/de/geschichte/> (19.10.2015);

²¹ Mühl was released in 1998 and lived with 14 members (all of them adults) for the rest of his life in Faro, Portugal.

pressure. He made lot of mistakes, but he did more right.“²² Putting the finger on the hierarchy issue, Claudia Mühl confessed *„I was really naïve, not realizing it (being on the top as first wife of the commune).*“²³

This group pressure, conformity and alienation to parenthood especially affected children. On of this kids found a way to deal with his past by showing the truth. Paul-Julien Robert made history by directing a small-budget production titled *„Meine keine Familie“* („My none family“)²⁴. There he shows what Otto Mühl understood by self-expression. Claudia Mühl’s reaction: *„I was not aware of the situation that kids can be afraid by pressure.*“²⁵

Claudia Mühl was as well arrested for child abuse. Her perspective on this issue, years later in this interview: *„I wanted to achieve an idea. My emotionlessness fulfills me today with shame. I violated a law I was not able to understand at this point in my life.*“²⁶ Moreover she answered after a question if she ever talked afterwards to any kid, who had got abused by her: *„More and more when I think about and talk so some of this people, I realize that the reality in this group was not as beautiful as it was for me. The ideology produced silent sorrows.*“²⁷

Earlier, in 2013, a girl of “Friedrichshof” and nowadays a student of the University of Arts in Vienna, gave one of the very few interviews about her childhood in the commune. She, Hatschepsut Huss (Otto Mühl tended to ancient names), remembered, that her childhood had been beautiful in the middle of a green island, but admitted when Mühl got convicted, she was five years old and so far too young for any commune’s rituals. In a very honest way by reflecting her mother’s role and position, she explained: *“My mother was there right from the beginning and died several years ago at*

²² Anke Richter, Claudia Mühl: “Wir haben die stärksten Tabus verletzt”, in: Die Presse, http://diepresse.com/home/leben/mensch/4635490/Claudia-Muhl_Wir-haben-die-staerksten-Tabus-verletzt (20.10.2015);

²³ Richter, Claudia Mühl, in: http://diepresse.com/home/leben/mensch/4635490/Claudia-Muhl_Wir-haben-die-staerksten-Tabus-verletzt (20.10.2015);

²⁴ Meine keine Familie, Paul-Julien Robert, Documentary Austria 2012;

²⁵ Richter, Claudia Mühl, in: http://diepresse.com/home/leben/mensch/4635490/Claudia-Muhl_Wir-haben-die-staerksten-Tabus-verletzt (20.10.2015);

²⁶ Richter, Claudia Mühl, in: http://diepresse.com/home/leben/mensch/4635490/Claudia-Muhl_Wir-haben-die-staerksten-Tabus-verletzt (20.10.2015);

²⁷ Richter, Claudia Mühl, in: http://diepresse.com/home/leben/mensch/4635490/Claudia-Muhl_Wir-haben-die-staerksten-Tabus-verletzt (20.10.2015);

“Friedrichshofs”. I think one reason why she never left was that it would had been - after the collapse of the commune - an extraordinary difficulty for women without formal education and with several children to survive outside. Especially because of the initial beginning where everyone thought this would last forever.”²⁸

Peter Stöckl, cultural sociologist and faculty member at the University of Applied Arts in Vienna²⁹ did his PhD researches on the last years of the Mühl commune. He stated in an interview: *„Most of them, who were involved, awaked from a nightmare.”³⁰*

The Mühl commune was not an outstanding factor at the end of the 1960s, there were a lot flat-sharing communities. Moreover there had been many other - quite similar - concepts in history like the John Humphrey Noyes commune in Oneida (New York State) in the 2nd part of the 19th century or the so called „Himmelhof“ from 1897-1898 in Vienna. So Mühl tried something which already had existed but under completely new circumstances.³¹

Otto Mühl as part of the up-coming social revolution of the 1960s, as a profiled artist and member of the most lively art scene of Austria at this time and gifted as a charismatic human being, he had a wonderful base to gather people and to present them his idea of a perfect community in this cold and unfriendly world. At this time in his life he was not only authentic; he was truly convinced that they could together create a new social life. Just after a few years, people in this commune got more and more lost and driven by social group dynamics.

Analysis

Definitely: Mühl was one of Austrians most polarizing artists. At the beginning, at the zenith of this power and even after his death, Otto Mühl -

²⁸ David Bogner, Ein Interview mit einem Mädchen aus der Mühl-Kommune, in: Vice, <http://www.vice.com/alps/read/otto-muehl-kommune-friedrichshof-interview-hatschepsut> (20.10.2015);

²⁹ CV Peter Stöckl, Universität für angewandte Kunst Wien, <http://www.dieangewandte.at/jart/prj3/angewandte/main.jart?rel=de&reserve-mode=active&content-id=1229508258594&Pe-Id=2602> (28.10.2015);

³⁰ Michael Huber, Muehl: Niemand dachte an die Kinder, in: Kurier, <http://kurier.at/kultur/kunst/otto-muehl-niemand-dachte-an-die-kinder/13.934.718> (29.10.2015);

³¹ Cf. Huber, Muehl: Niemand dachte an die Kinder, in: <http://kurier.at/kultur/kunst/otto-muehl-niemand-dachte-an-die-kinder/13.934.718> (29.10.2015);

more than all of his other colleagues - defined his life as an art work. He dedicated his lifetime to a new concept of living without realizing that under his idea of a common commune life, a huge wrongfulness became increasingly widespread. He lost control and ignored essential critics by his followers. At the end, an institutional power, the court, assumed responsibility. Beside his role as artist and rebel of so called conventional lifestyle, he became a criminal. His influential thinking in the 1960s of new sexual, gender and relationship patterns and concepts, his deep believe in possibilities to be free and independent and his charismatic conviction that the time was open to new ideas, built up a commune of hope but finally failed dramatically.

Especially left-wing politicians, from the beginning of this open-minded experiment, were consistently attracted by the success of the Mühl commune. It seemed to be possible to create another form of collective responsibility. In the 1990s, in the middle of a third way understanding of political socialism, Otto Mühl became ironically an example for collective system failing. Additionally after the fall of the Soviet Union, even common property in a small commune, so a widespread understanding of the time, did not work out.

For sure: a lot of research has to be done to be able to see clearly what happened in the 1960s and the following decades in detail. There are many commune members still alive and perhaps with a little time of distance to what happened, archive documents, which are already available, and oral history studies for an individual perspective on the everyday life, can help tackling such a topic.

The Otto Mühl commune archive, now located at the „Friedrichshof“ and founded by former members of this commune, provides all existing materials to an interested audience. This is one first important step to shed light on all issues of the past.

At least and for sure: Mühl's heritage, his life and his commune experiment, is a very interesting part of Austrian contemporary history and worth to be more in focus of a gender/queer research agenda.

There are the pictures in addition about life and work of Otto Mühl to see on³²: <http://kurier.at/kultur/kunst/verehrt-und-verurteilt-aktionist-und-kommunengruender-otto-muehl/13.846.088/slideshow>

³² Kurier, Slideshow „Verehrt und verurteilt: Aktionist und Kommunengründer Otto Muehl“ (2.11.2015);